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A FIELD GUIDE FROM PERSEVERANT DIGITAL · FOR INDUSTRIAL SERVICES

How to Win Planned Plant Work Before the Bid List Is Set

Most planned plant work is decided months before the RFQ goes out. Get cleared, understood and remembered early, so the outage plan already has your name on it.

THE SHORT ANSWER · 61 WORDS REVIEWED OCTOBER 20, 2026

Get on the shortlist before the bid list is set. Map each target plant's outage calendar, clear its prequalification, publish plain answers engineers can check, reach every person who signs off, and stay in touch between outages by email and LinkedIn. Then track what a site walkdown and an awarded job cost from each source, and do more of what wins.

The call comes at 2 a.m. A steam line is leaking and the plant can’t shut down. Your crew is on site by morning and the line keeps running. The maintenance manager thanks you, and you head home.

Six months later the same plant relines three tanks during its spring outage. The work goes to another contractor. Nobody was unhappy with you. The outage plan was simply built, and its contractors chosen, while you were busy answering the next emergency.

That is how many good repair firms end up living on word of mouth and night calls. The emergency work proves you can do the job. The planned work, the larger and steadier jobs, is decided earlier and by more people. Winning it takes a different plan.

Where does your planned work come from today?

Start with the last 12 months. Most owners guess “referrals” and stop there. Split it out, because each source costs something different to win and keep.

Source	Planned jobs won	Revenue	Avg. job size	What it cost to win
Emergency call that turned into planned work				
RFQ from an approved vendor list				
Plant staff who moved to a new site				
Website, search or AI assistant inquiry				
Trade show or association event				
LinkedIn or email outreach				
Distributor or engineering firm referral				

“What it cost to win” includes estimating hours, site walkdowns, travel and any ad or event spend. If one row carries most of the revenue, that is both your strength and your risk.

When is the work actually decided?

Earlier than the RFQ suggests. In the 6sense 2025 B2B Buyer Experience Report, a survey of nearly 4,000 B2B buyers, buyers filled about 3.6 shortlist spots on the first day of their search. The winner came from that day-one list 95% of the time. Buyers made first contact with sellers about 61% of the way through their process, and 79% of the time the buyer reached out first. The study covers B2B buying broadly, not plants alone.

Plant work adds a calendar. Planned repairs are usually scoped well before the RFQ goes out, so by the time it arrives, the scope often reflects whoever was already in the room.

So build the calendar for the plants you want.

Plant	Next outage window	Planning starts	Who plans it	Our last touch	Next step

If you don’t know a plant’s outage window, that is your first question for the people you already know there.

Are you cleared to work there?

A safety review can stall an award you’ve already earned. Many plants screen contractors through a third-party prequalification platform before anyone signs a purchase order. ISNetworld, one of the largest, says it has 90,000 contractor and supplier subscribers searchable by 900 hiring clients (ISNetworld, accessed October 20, 2026). Avetta and others serve the same role for other owners. Each plant chooses its own platform and its own scoring.

- [ ] List which platform each target plant uses, and your current grade or status in each
- [ ] Keep safety statistics, written programs and training records current, not just before a review
- [ ] Have insurance certificates ready to send to purchasing the same day they ask
- [ ] Register with each plant’s purchasing team and ask to be added to the RFQ list for your work type
- [ ] Assign one person to watch for expiring documents every month

Being cleared doesn’t win work. Being uncleared loses it quietly.

Will an engineer find you, and understand what you do?

Engineers do a lot of the work before they call. The 2026 State of Marketing to Engineers report from TREW Marketing and GlobalSpec (March 2026, more than 1,100 engineers and technical professionals) found engineers spend 62% of the buying journey researching online. 69% now use generative AI during some part of the purchase. They rated their trust in AI answers 4.7 out of 10, so they check what AI tells them against technical publications and vendor websites. 70% said they’re more likely to choose the better-known brand when two solutions look technically similar.

Two things follow. Your website has to hold the answers an engineer will check. And the plain-language version of those answers has to exist somewhere an AI assistant can read and repeat. We call this Search Essence Optimization: your buyers aren't only searching to find you, they're searching to understand you.

For each repair method you want more of, can your site answer these?

- [ ] Can it be done while the system stays in service, and when can't it?
- [ ] Which repair standards or codes do you work to, and when is an engineered design needed?
- [ ] What service life should the plant expect, and what affects it?
- [ ] How long is your crew on site, and what do you need from the plant (permits, access, isolation)?
- [ ] What should the engineer send you first (photos, thickness readings, drawings, service conditions)?
- [ ] What does a recent, similar job look like (method, asset, conditions, outcome), shown without naming the plant?

One page per method and asset type usually beats one long services page.

Who else has to say yes?

Plant work rarely has one buyer. A maintenance manager may find you first. A reliability engineer checks the method. Procurement compares rates and terms. Safety reviews your record and your site plan. Any one of them can stall a good job.

Role	What they need to know	What you send them
Maintenance manager	Can you respond, and will the repair hold?	Response plan, similar jobs, references
Reliability or process engineer	Is the method sound for these conditions?	Method sheet, standards, inspection and test records
Procurement	Rates, terms, insurance, vendor setup	Rate sheet, certificates, W-9, vendor forms
Safety (EHS)	Your record and how you'll work on site	Prequalification status, safety plan, training records

Send each person their part directly. Don’t count on the first contact to forward everything.

How do you stay remembered between outages?

The 2026 State of Marketing to Engineers findings, reported by Napier in May 2026, say engineers prefer email to phone outreach. Use that. A short note with something useful, such as a case write-up, an inspection checklist or an invitation to a lunch-and-learn, keeps you known without wearing out your welcome.

LinkedIn helps reach the people you haven’t met. LinkedIn says its ads can target by job title, company, industry and seniority, and can reach a list of companies or contacts you upload. That means you can put a case write-up in front of reliability engineers at the twenty plants on your calendar, and no one else.

A simple schedule tied to each plant’s outage:

When	Touch
9–12 months before the outage	Short email to maintenance and reliability with a relevant case write-up
6–9 months before	Ask for a site walkdown of the assets you could help with
3–6 months before	Send method sheets and the documents procurement and safety need
30 days after the outage	Ask what went well and what’s coming next year

Email rules still apply. The FTC says the CAN-SPAM Act makes no exception for business-to-business email: accurate headers, a postal address, and an opt-out honored within 10 business days. Not legal advice.

And when the emergency call does come, answer it with a person, fast. Harvard Business Review’s 2011 study of online sales leads found firms that contacted leads within an hour were nearly seven times as likely to qualify them as firms that waited longer. The 2 a.m. save is still how many plants meet you.

What does an awarded job cost you?

Judge every source by awarded work, not inquiries. Three numbers tell you

most of it:

- **Cost per walkdown** = what you spent on a source ÷ site walkdowns it produced
- **Walkdown-to-bid rate** = bids submitted ÷ walkdowns
- **Cost per awarded job** = what you spent on a source ÷ jobs awarded from it

Example numbers, not benchmarks. A firm spends $6,000 over a quarter on LinkedIn and email for one region. That produces 8 walkdowns, 5 bids and 2 awarded jobs. Cost per walkdown is $750. Cost per awarded job is $3,000. Compare it across sources before deciding where the next dollar goes.

Plants also feel the cost of waiting. Siemens' True Cost of Downtime 2024 report found a large plant still loses an average of 27 hours a month to unplanned downtime, down from 39 in 2019. Planned repair that prevents the next failure is worth explaining well.

Where do most owners get stuck?

> **Knowing which plants are planning now.** Outage windows and scoping dates live in people's heads. Keeping a calendar current across dozens of plants takes steady effort that slips when crews get busy.

> **Being findable for the exact repair.** Engineers search for their asset and their failure, not your company name. Writing pages they trust, and that AI assistants can describe correctly, takes time most estimators don't have.

> **Connecting outreach to awarded work.** Without a simple link between email, LinkedIn, walkdowns and awards, you can't tell which effort is paying off, so the plan drifts back to waiting for the phone.

If one of these sounds familiar, book a 25-minute exploration call with the short form at the end of this guide. We'll look at your plants, your sources and your site, and tell you plainly what we'd fix first.

Sources

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- Harvard Business Review, “The Short Life of Online Sales Leads,” March 2011. link
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Want a second set of eyes on your plan?

Book a free 25-minute exploration call. We will look at your numbers with you, name the first fixes in order, and tell you honestly if we are not the right fit.

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